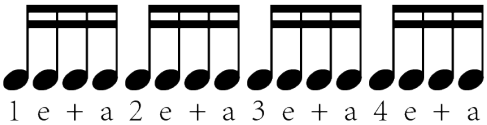
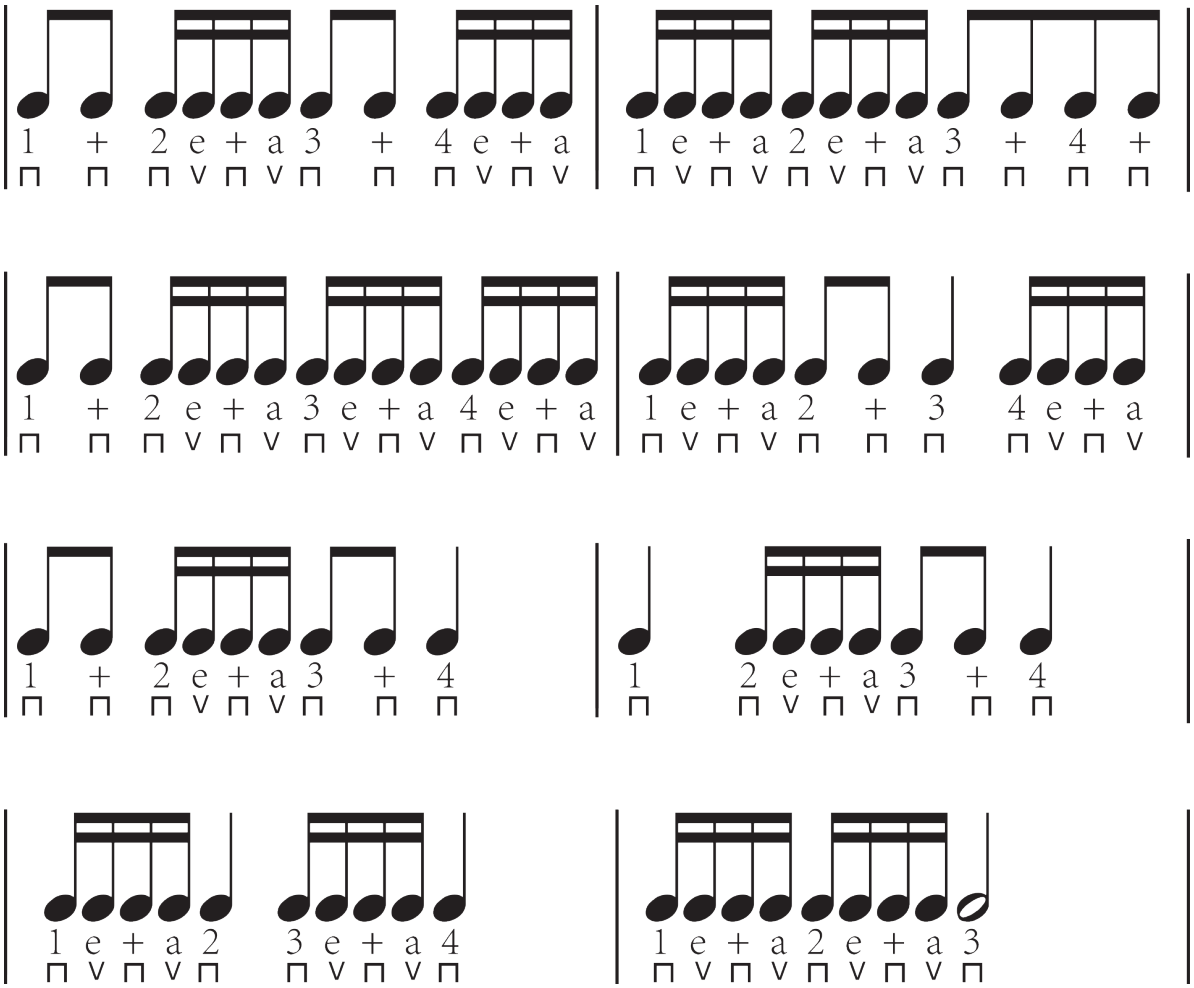
LESSON 20: SIXTEENTH NOTES

Sixteenth notes are twice as fast as eighth notes. That means they're played at a speed of four-per-beat, since each takes up 1/4 of a beat. In isolation, sixteenth notes have two flags hanging from the top of their stem. When grouped together, you'll see them connected with a double beam as shown below.

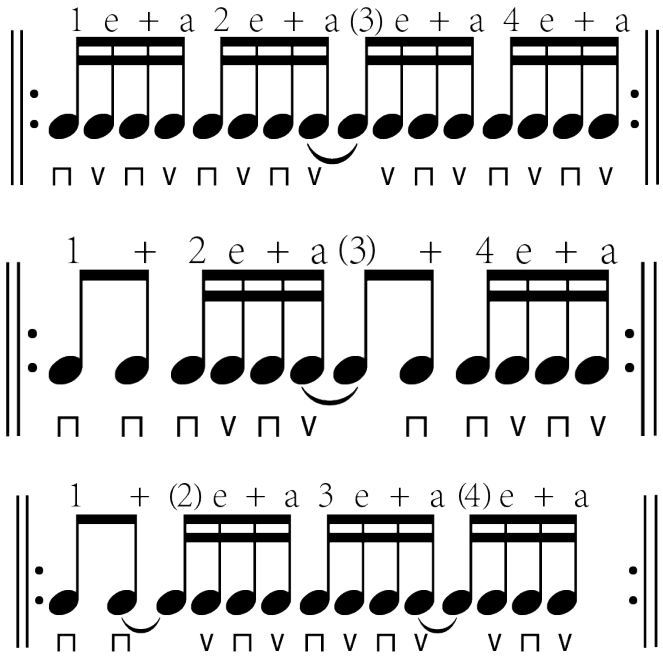
Value	*Symbol*	*Rest*	*Counts*
1/4 beat			

To count sixteenth notes, we keep our other counts in place (one and two and, etc.) but now place two new counting syllables in between: "e" (pronounced "eee") and "a" (pronounce "uh") . At first, this can be a tongue twister and might even seem a bit silly, but with time it will become an easy task to vocalize and will serve as a helpful way to keep track of fast rhythms.

The long exercise on the next page will introduce you to some simple examples of how sixteenth notes might appear in a measure. Practice it first by only counting to a steady pulse. Once that's comfortable, play the rhythm by strumming down on beats 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +, then strum up on the "e" and "a" counts. Consider practicing this with no chord at all, and only a rested/muted strum, to ensure your focus is purely on the timing.

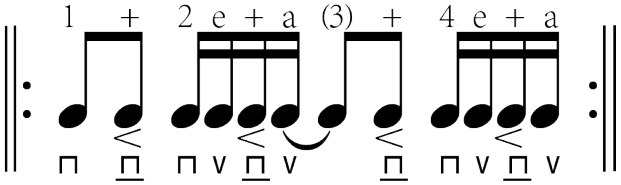


Once those basic rhythms are comfortable, experiment with adding in syncopation as demonstrated in these three examples below.

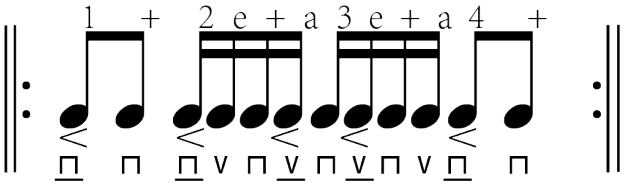


Adding Accents

These two exercises feature sixteenth notes and accents. For this first one, you'll switch between G and Em on each repeat. Begin by slowly counting the rhythm, ensuring you're accenting the proper counts. Then, add in the strums along with your counting. This time, we'll only accent the "ands."

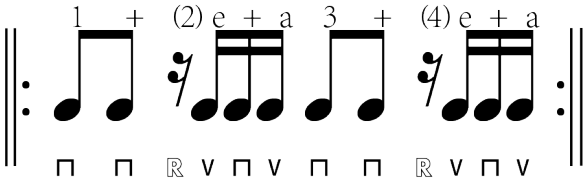


For this exercise, switch between E and Asus2 on every repeat. Again, begin by counting first, and pay close attention to the accenting pattern.

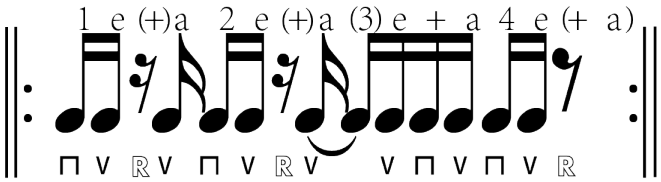
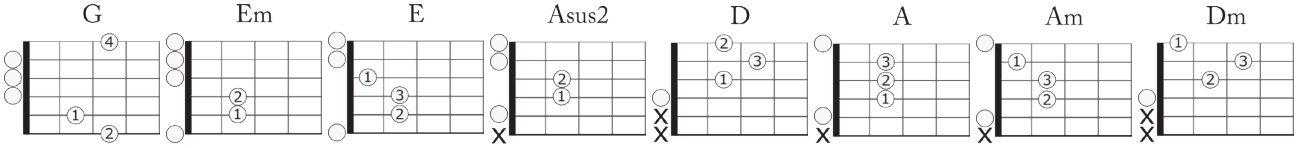


Adding Rests

We'll now apply rests alongside our sixteenth note strums. For this first exercise, cycle through the progression D - Em - G - A.



For this exercise, cycle through the chords Am - Dm - Am - E



CHORDS USED FOR THIS LESSON